

In what follows, I'll set preference hedonism to the side, and focus on the success theory. Most of the issues that will come up would also apply to preference hedonism — so if you prefer that view, you can substitute accordingly.

Here's a problem for the view that desires play the central role which
the success theory gives to them:

Consider this example. Knowing that you accept a Summative theory, I tell you that I am about to make your life go better. I shall inject you with an addictive drug. From now on, you will wake each morning with an extremely strong desire to have another injection of this drug. Having this desire will be in itself neither pleasant nor painful, but if the desire is not fulfilled within an hour it will then become very painful. This is no cause for concern, since I shall give you ample supplies of this drug. Every morning, you will be able at once to fulfil this desire. The injection, and its after-effects, would also be neither pleasant nor painful. You will spend the rest of your days as you do now.

Would it make your life go better to be injected with the addictive
drug?

Intuitively, no. You will always have to remember to have ample supplies of the drug around, and will have to give yourself an injection every morning. None of these are things that you want to do.

On the other hand, if you take the drug, you will have a whole new group of extremely strong desires: the desire to take the drug each morning of your life. And each of these extremely strong desires will be satisfied. But according to the success theory, having your desires — especially your very strong desires — satisfied if what makes your life go well. So according to the success theory, taking the drug does make your life go (much) better.

This is of course a made up case. But there are real life cases which are
relevantly like it.

Violet is a softball player. Every time she comes to the plate, she wants very badly to get a hit. But softball is hard, and even the best players don't get hits most of the time. So, knowing that her life goes worse when her strongly held desires about her life are not met, Violet decides to get rid of this desire. Now when she comes to the plate, does not desire to get a hit. She gets hits less often now; but her life is better, since now her desires are not frustrated.

But even after we introduce this distinction between summative and global theories, one might think that a problem somewhat like the one posed by the case of Violet remains. This is brought out by the example of the grass-counter:

Consider the man that Rawls imagined who wants to spend his life counting the numbers of blades of grass in different lawns. Suppose that this man knows that he could achieve great progress if instead he worked in some especially useful part of Applied Mathematics. Though he could achieve such significant results, he prefers to go on counting blades of grass. On the Success Theory, if we allow this theory to cover all imaginable cases, it could be better for this person if he counted his blades of grass rather than achieving great and useful mathematical results.

Here the desire to spend his life counting blades of grass is a global desire. So even the global success theory has to say that the man has a better life counting blades of grass than he would have achieving great and useful things in mathematics.

One can have two different kinds of reactions to this case.

First, one might regard this result as unproblematic. If this is what the man wants to spend his life doing, then his best life genuinely is spent counting blades of grass.

On the other hand, one might regard this as a waste of a life. Counting blades of grass is pointless; and a life spent doing pointless things can't be a good life.

One way to bring out the second response is to imagine that the grass-counter is someone you love — perhaps a child. Suppose that you want them to have the best life possible, and that you know that they desire life as a grass-counter. Wouldn't you still hope that they moved on from grass-counting at some point?

If you think this, then this would be a reason to abandon the success
theory in favor of what Parfit calls an **objective list theory**.

An objective list theory says that a good life is one which contains certain features — the ones on the objective list of good-making features. What gets on the list is not determined by what you want — it is something fixed independently of your desires.

The objective list theorist can say that, despite his global desires, the grass-counter would have lived a better life by spending his time on other pursuits.

Let's forget about human lives for a second, and think about the lives of non-human animals. Consider the following two beasts:





We can ask, of either animal, what it would take for their life to go best. Do we get the same answer in the two cases?

As with consequentialism and deontology, there are various different specific versions of virtue ethics. But as in those cases, I'll focus in on one, which is a version of a kind of theory called **perfectionism**. This kind of theory goes back to Aristotle.

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There are different answers to this question. The one we will explore

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